Brussels bets big on Canada

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【メール原文】

Presented by TikTok By SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC with NICHOLAS VINOCUR and GREGORIO SORGI GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, sharing my birthday wit

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GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, sharing my birthday with a historic EU-Canada summit. For me? You shouldn’t have.

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In today’s Playbook:

— Trump casts a shadow over high-stakes Montreal summit.

— Norway promises to protect the ICC from Washington.

— Faces in the crowd: Mark Carney, Espen Barth Eide, Ursula von der Leyen, Theo Francken, Reem Alabali Radovan, Tove Lo, Kaja Kallas and more …

On today’s Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah discuss how bad relationships with the U.S. have pushed the EU and Canada into a rebound romance.

A message from TikTok: Did you know TikTok advertising generated €31 billion in economic output across the EU in 2025? New research shows the platform helped businesses grow, supporting €13 billion in additional economic output for small and medium-sized businesses and helping millions of businesses reach customers across borders.

DRIVING THE DAY

HERE WE GO: Canada and the EU are racing to lock in closer ties at a summit today, with both sides hoping Donald Trump is too distracted by the U.S. midterms to retaliate, five EU officials and two Canadian diplomats told me.

It's a full house: European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, European Council President António Costa and a small army of commissioners and EU officials are descending on Montreal for a grand two-day talkfest with Prime Minister Mark Carney, who wants to create an alliance of middle-power democracies as a counterweight to Washington.

Trump's shadow looms: While von der Leyen has been at pains to clarify that Brussels and Ottawa's alliance is "not against anybody else," Brussels is not naïve and knows the U.S. is watching, a senior EU official said. Trump has already vowed to lash out in the form of "serious tariffs" if the two sides get too close for his comfort.

But that's not stopping the EU, which is seizing this rare moment to secure expansive new ties with over 40 million Canadians and their €2 trillion economy, and won't let the prospect of American retaliation get in the way, another senior EU official said. Carney knows he won't get another chance like this and is pushing for "structural changes," two Canadian diplomats said.

Now or never: Ottawa wants to lock in concrete gains before Europe's political priorities shift, a Canadian diplomat said. "It's very fortunate we're doing this summit now and not in six months," the diplomat said, referring to the French election, with far-right candidate Marine Le Pen leading the polls, and the seemingly unstoppable rise of the far right across Europe.

The stakes couldn't be higher: Brussels and Ottawa will commit themselves to cooperate on trade, energy, security, education, the Arctic and more, according to a joint statement obtained by POLITICO .

A note on terminology: Their pact will not be called "associate membership" after that term was dropped from the summit's joint statement due to opposition from Germany … although von der Leyen was notably still using it to describe the relationship in a statement — even after Berlin had made sure it got cut — and social post on Wednesday night.

The real prize: The EU–Canada partnership could serve as a model for other countries seeking to join a Carney-style alliance with the bloc at the center, a third senior EU official said.

Bigger fish to fry: Another EU official predicted the U.S. president would be too focused on the Nov. 3 midterms to care about what's happening up north. His Republican Party is polling badly in key races and is expected to lose the House.

Managing expectations: Trump won't be bothered, a fifth senior EU official predicted, but only because the EU–Canada summit will mostly just produce "some nice pictures," which won't be enough to "trigger" the president.

Who's who: Here are the key players on either side of the Atlantic at today's summit, from Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich and POLITICO's Ottawa Bureau Chief Nick Taylor-Vaisey.

What to watch: Von der Leyen will deliver a keynote on EU-Canada relations at 2:50 p.m., Brussels time, with Costa addressing the Montreal Council on Foreign Relations at 6 p.m. and both EU leaders joining Carney at a business forum at 7 p.m. View it live here . More details below, in Agenda.

O NO, CANADA! Meanwhile, Ben Makuch and Mike Blanchfield write that Canada is a major fossil fuel producer whose climate ambitions fall far short of Europe's … and that under Carney those ambitions

are weakening .

BIG AND BREAKING

RISING TOLL OF SPANISH TRAIN CRASH: The regional government of Castilla La Mancha had confirmed the death toll of at least 68 people in Wednesday's high-speed train accident in the Toledo province, with another 58 people receiving medical treatment, AP reports . The disaster has raised fresh questions about Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's management of public infrastructure, weeks ahead of a snap election.

Lawmakers respond: In a statement to Playbook overnight, the European Parliament said that "in mourning and solidarity with Spain," it had lowered the Spanish flag to half mast in all three places of work, as well as at the European Parliament Liaison Office in Madrid and the regional EP office in Barcelona.

ISRAEL FRAUD ALLEGATIONS: Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's Likud party has said voter fraud perpetrated by Arab citizens prevented its leader from winning a clear victory in the country's election. The claims come as Netanyahu's rivals weigh joining forces with Arab parties to secure a majority.

FRONTEX VS. FREE SPEECH: New powers proposed for the EU's border police Frontex to monitor social media pose a threat to free speech , European lawmakers and civil society groups told Eliza Gkritsi.

UKRAINE'S PEACE CONCERNS: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy worries that a new escalation in the U.S.-Iran war could derail negotiations over a truce in Ukraine, as diplomatic activity ramps up in a fresh attempt to close in on a ceasefire.

TRUMP-PROOFING THE ICC

OSLO VOWS TO KEEP ICC AFLOAT: Norway stands ready to provide material help to the International Criminal Court to ensure "active business continuity" as it faces the threat of U.S. sanctions, Norwegian Foreign Minister Espen Barth Eide told Nick Vinocur.

It takes a village: "We are in close contact with the Netherlands, with Germany, Iceland, with a number of like-minded countries looking for ways not only to speak up for the ICC, but to ensure business continuity, whether it's economic continuity or helping them continue to operate," Eide said in a phone interview.

Weak spot: The United States does not provide funding for the ICC. But the court is heavily dependent on U.S. service providers for payments and IT systems, which would be shut off if the sanctions come into effect, with potentially dramatic effects on its ability to operate.

Warning: Eide didn't spell out how Norway or others could help the ICC (EU chief diplomat Kaja Kallas extended a similar offer of operational support when she visited The Hague earlier this month). But he did argue that Europe should develop alternatives to U.S. technology if these are "weaponized to punish things important to Europe."

Make it in Europe? "The only answer," he added, "is to supplement U.S. technology with European alternatives," while a "longer-term" response is to "boost European autonomy in data platforms.

Zoom out: The United States, which has already sanctioned 13 senior officials from the ICC, has announced sanctions against the court itself, but these won't apply for another six months. Meanwhile, the Netherlands is looking to convince the U.S. not to follow through with its sanctions threat — while supportive nations such as Norway, along with the EU, try to prepare for a worst-case scenario.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The EU has delayed the deadline to apply to build AI data centers … but what is the plan and why a delay? The Commission fired the starting gun in July for consortia to bid on the construction of seven gigafactories (large-scale facilities dedicated to the development and training of next-generation AI models) at a total estimated cost of €30 billion. The new deadlines (of either December of February, depending on the size of the project) are to give "member states the necessary time to complete their national budgetary process and submit financial commitments."

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MIND THE BUDGET GAP

UKRAINE LOANS OPEN €35B BUDGET HOLE: The EU's next seven-year budget will have to find at least €35 billion to repay old loans to Ukraine, as leaders race to agree fresh funding for Kyiv during an upcoming summit, Gregorio Sorgi reports.

Summit twins: The Commission has doled out €171 billion in loans to Ukraine since 2014, with most disbursements coming after Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022, the Commission wrote in a note seen by Playbook. EU leaders will gather in Brussels for a special summit on Nov. 26-27 to negotiate the next seven-year budget and commit themselves to raise a further €45 billion for Ukraine in 2027.

The EU will repay last year's €90 billion loan after the war ends, but the interest rates are already weighing on the next budget. The EU stands to repay €35 billion in borrowing costs from 2028 to 2034 — or €41.9 billion, if interest rates rise by 1%, according to the note sent to EU governments.

"The Union budget is equipped to address these costs and has sufficient financial capacities within the headroom [financial cushion]," a Commission official told Playbook. But the EU executive wrote in the note that "a source of coverage [for the borrowing costs] is to be defined."

EUCO showdown: This sets the scene for tough discussions, as Hungary, Czechia, Slovakia and Bulgaria insist that they don't want to service the borrowing costs for any future loan — creating annoyance among Ukraine's allies.

DASHBOARD

Many EU citizens think highly of Canada — but that doesn't necessarily mean they think of the country as a key ally. In a September POLITICO Poll, independent pollster PF Global asked respondents in France, Spain and Germany to pick their country's most important allies. Canada ranked lower than other EU countries and also consistently behind the U.S. Results from a June POLITICO Poll, however, showed that many Europeans hold Canada in high regard. Large shares of respondents in France and

Germany said Canada has the happiest citizens and is the best place to live.

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

AI SELL-OFF: Investors piling into a small number of mega technology companies could have a "significant impact" on the economy if the artificial intelligence bet doesn't pay off , according to outgoing European Securities and Markets Authority Chair Verena Ross.

SHRINKING THE CIRCLE: After Playbook reported on a somewhat tense meeting at DG COMM a couple of weeks ago, the invitation list has been restricted to senior officials to prevent further leaks, Gerardo Fortuna has learned.

CUE VIOLINS: Coffee-machine prices have jumped 20% at the European Commission's Berlaymont headquarters, with a cup now setting staff back 60 cents, up from 50 cents, an EU official griped to Sebastian.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly sunny, with a high of 15C.

AMBASSADOR MOVE: Helen Winter, Germany's Coreper 1 ambassador, is leaving her post to return to Berlin, where she will take up a new role in the Federal Ministry for Economic Affairs and Energy, according to an EU diplomat. Viel Glück!

MUSICAL LUNCH, ANYONE? The weekend isn't that far away … So, why not upgrade your midday break with a free Ancienne Belgique concert and every Belgian's go-to lunch (bread)? On the menu today : Young musical talent Frans Kalf will preform, with his favorite sandwich on offer for €2,50: bread, butter and aged Dutch cheese, "prepared in the morning and left in a lunchbox for a few hours."

LET'S BOOGEY, MAN: The spookiest night of the year is drawing closer (Halloween, not another European Council). If you're ready to rave, C12 is throwing an eight-hour bash, with fog machines and DJ Luke Slater; the "Hangar Festival — Halloween Edition" will take place at Brussels Gate; Brasserie Illegaal is throwing a costumed rave; and Halloween XXL — The Brussels Hidden Theater is predicting 1,000 partygoers will dance the night away at Grand Casino. Some of these events are selling out, so grab tix sooner rather than later.

If you're looking for something a tad more family-friendly, Pumpkimania promises "an autumn spectacle for the whole family." There's also a "nearly one-kilometer-long Halloween event," replete with "moving puppets, light and sound effects in a spooky setting." Consider us spooked. Get tix here .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: German Minister Reem Alabali Radovan is in Lebanon today, with the issue of how to deal with Hezbollah hanging over her visit like a sword of Damocles.

Paris: Centrist Gabriel Attal has a plan: a primary of democrats for all candidates ready to rule out an alliance with the far left or far right.

Madrid: There are still too many unknowns surrounding the deadly train accident in Urda.

London: Andy Burnham is out selling a steady-as-she-goes budget that has held back on radical changes, as Britain battles the Iran energy shocks.

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AGENDA

— The 21st EU–Canada Summit opens in Montreal and runs through Friday. European Council President António Costa and Commission President Ursula von der Leyen represent the EU, with Prime Minister Mark Carney representing Canada. EU High Representative Kaja Kallas, Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič, Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius, Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu and Youth Commissioner Glenn Micallef are also attending. Leaders are expected to launch an "Alliance for the Future" and discuss trade, digital cooperation, critical raw materials, defense and security, energy and climate, Ukraine, and education and research. Costa is scheduled to speak at the Montreal Council on Foreign Relations at 6 p.m. CET (watch live); the Canada–EU Business Forum takes place at 7 p.m. CET.

— Von der Leyen delivers a keynote speech on EU–Canada relations at the C.D. Howe Institute and takes part in an EU–Canada business roundtable in Montreal. The event starts at 2 p.m. CET. Watch live .

— Šefčovič meets Canadian Finance and National Revenue Minister François-Philippe Champagne in Montreal.

— Mînzatu meets university leaders, faculty members and Erasmus+ students from universities in Montreal.

— Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné takes part in a ministerial roundtable on the Transition Accelerator and Clean Energy, visits a Nexans plant and joins the Canada–EU Business Leaders Forum's strategic roundtable in Montreal.

— Kubilius meets Canadian Space Agency Acting President Jean-Claude Piedboeuf in Montreal.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in the European Central Bank's Governing Council meeting in Frankfurt. ECB President Christine Lagarde to hold press conference at 2.45 p.m. Watch live .

— The Transport, Telecommunications and Energy Council meets in Luxembourg, with Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen in attendance. Ministers will discuss electricity network charges, energy security and possible energy targets for the post-2030 framework. Watch live .

— Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto visits Lavoriškės to meet local communities and Vilnius District Mayor Robert Duchnevič, then meets Lithuanian Finance Minister Taurimas Valys and Prime Minister Mindaugas Sinkevičius in Vilnius.

— Equality Commissioner Hadja Lahbib delivers the opening speech at UNESCO's Global Forum against Racism and Discrimination in The Hague, at 9:30 a.m., in the presence of Dutch King Willem-Alexander. She also meets U.N. Deputy High Commissioner for Human Rights Awa Dabo and UNESCO Deputy Director-General Åsa Regnér. Watch live .

— Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin meets Bulgarian Prime Minister Rumen Radev and Finance Minister Galab Donev in Sofia.

— Research Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva meets Bulgarian Education and Science Minister Georgi Valchev and takes part in the Crossroads Startup Event, a European Innovation Council Info Day and the EURAXESS Biennial Conference in Sofia.

— The sixth edition of the European Defence and Security Conference takes place in Brussels, with Kublius delivering the opening address (via video), alongside Belgian Defense Minister Theo Francken. The program is here.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP César Luena; former MEPs Marco Zullo and Bettina Vollath; U.S. Ambassador to NATO Matthew Whitaker; POLITICO's Sebastian Starcevic; Belarusian opposition politician Hanna Kanapatskaya; Swedish singer Tove Lo.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Gregorio Sorgi and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

A message from TikTok: Did you know TikTok advertising generated €31 billion in economic output across the EU in 2025? New independent research shows the platform helped businesses grow, acting as a discovery engine for opportunity across the European economy. The impact goes well beyond the app. Advertising on TikTok helped generate €13 billion in additional economic output for small and medium-sized businesses, while more than 6.5 million EU businesses used TikTok to reach customers across borders. Discovery on TikTok helps small businesses connect with new customers, creators reach new audiences, and useful ideas and skills travel between countries. These connections can translate into real-world growth, from increased sales for local businesses to new opportunities for entrepreneurs and creators. Across the EU, TikTok is turning online discovery into economic activity, helping businesses grow and connecting people and products across borders.

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